George would not participate in the debate as long as they were part of it.

Since I had invited them, I couldn't go along with him and exclude the other candidates, so we were at an impasse, a strange, awkward impasse.

George just sat frozen in his chair, not saying anything; I sat in the other chair with the four other candidates standing behind me, looking embarrassed in front of two or three thousand people while being literally told they had to leave.

Unable to understand what was going on, the audience hooted and hollered and urged us to proceed.

I decided I should explain to the crowd what the delay was all about and started to speak.

But as I did, an editor of the Nashua newspaper shouted to the sound man, *"Turn Mr. Reagan's microphone off."*

Well, I didn't like that—we were paying the freight for the debate and he was acting as if his newspaper was still sponsoring it—and so I turned to him, with the microphone still on, and said the first thing that came to my mind: *"I am paying for this microphone, Mr. Breen."*

Well, for some reason my words hit the audience, whose emotions were already worked up, like a sledgehammer. The crowd roared and just went wild.

I may have won the debate, the primary—and the nomination—right there. After the debate, our people told me the gymnasium parking lot was littered with Bush-for-President badges.

During the weeks following the Iowa caucuses when I'd been trying to make a comeback, the bickering, tension, and morale problems on our staff because of John Sears's efforts to exert total control over the campaign had reached a boiling point again.

I thought Sears was smart and talented, but he became angry if I spoke to anyone but him about campaign affairs